

with clean drinking water, and disabled people with prosthetic legs. Basic human needs will be met at much lower costs and hence 3D printing can serve as an impetus to economic development. But as with all futuristic technologies, the seemingly infinitesimal scope that 3D printing offers also raises eyebrows with respect to the all the negatives that it can cause. The technology of 3D printing is advancing so quickly in so many different fields that its advantages and repercussions might hit the average consumer hard, even before he/she realises what's happening.

- ▶ **Unemployment:** To start off, it is clear that because of the added advantages that 3D printed products give you, including accuracy and lesser waste, mass manufacturers would love to incorporate 3D printers on every stage of their supply chain. The small part of manufacturing that is 3D printing, today, might well go on to become the main component of an era of silent factories where companies can churn out a number of cutting-edge parts required for mass manufacturing with absolutely no labourer in sight. So, while reducing cheap labour might be cutting down costs for the company, it also means a major cut down on jobs, and thus, mass unemployment. And though a new era of manufacturing would require skill to be diverted into new areas – for operation of the 3D printers, and for making custom designs etc. – the switch from one skill set to another will not be convenient, and perhaps not feasible for many. Thus, inevitable or not, an industrial revolution leading to mass unemployment is a scary prospect.
- ▶ **Weapons:** What is scarier though, is the fact that 3D printing gives you the chance to create absolutely anything you think of - including guns.



3D Printed Metal Gun Components Disassembled

3D printers could have significant positive economic and social benefits, but as with everything that is human, they also have a dark side. And firearms are clearly the most problematic 3D printed devices that could be produced. There are schematics available for printable plastic guns already, and as the technology advances, it could